

a futile effort to save the job he had already proved he could not possibly handle.

I believe it was La Rochefoucauld who first argued that

"nothing is impossible." In my opinion, this is sheer nonsense and I flatly reject the theory, noting that even La Rochefoucauld felt it advisable to later amend his adage to read: "Few things are impossible in themselves."

I'm inclined to cock a skeptical eye at even this revised version. However, rather than further disparage the good Duc de La Rochefoucauld's philosophies, I'll assume that our definitions of the word "few" differ greatly and let it go at that. In any event, he was referring to matters on a more esoteric plane—while I am concerned with the hard-fact specifics of everyday living and particularly of business.

It is my opinion—and it has been my experience—that there are vast numbers of things which are impossible and that one is very likely to encounter them frequently in the business world. I firmly believe that one of the most valuable assets a businessman or executive can possess is

140

the ability to study and weigh all the factors in a given situation and determine what is feasible and what is not—

in short, to distinguish between the possible and the impossible. The ability is seldom innate; rather, it is acquired and developed. With it, an individual's chances of achieving success are greatly enhanced. Without it, he can go only so far—or fail altogether. Many an otherwise capable—or even great—man has failed because he lacked this capacity.

A comparison between Julius Caesar and Augustus Caesar indicates that Julius was basically the more able and gifted of the two. But Julius did not have the judgment and sense of proportion to separate the wheat of the possible from the chaff of the impossible—and this is what ultimately led to his downfall and assassination.